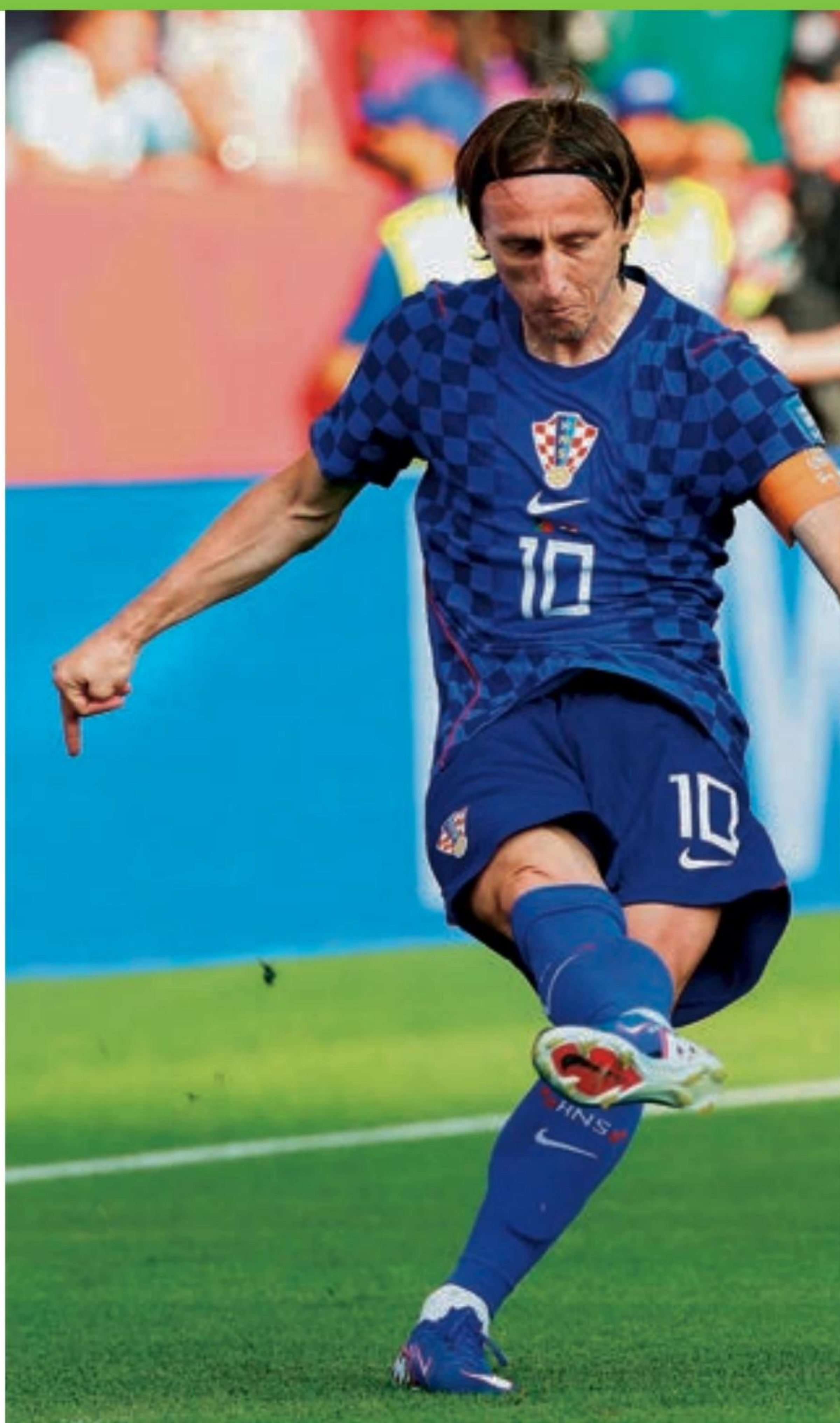




Time's embrace: Neymar and Luka Modric left the World Cup in defeat, their departures symbolising the slow, inevitable changing of football's generations. AFP & REUTERS

It recalls, in its own way, those late-career years of Sachin Tendulkar, when Indian cricket seemed to understand that every innings, every tour, every knock might be one of the last chances to honour a figure who had towered over its imagination for a generation. The runs still mattered, but so did the ceremony of care around him, the collective desire to protect the ending of someone who had given so much.

Maybe that is why these exits land differently as we get older. When we

were younger, sporting heroes felt eternal. Tendulkar seemed as though he had always existed and somehow always would. Then came Roger Federer, making tennis look too graceful to be real; Rafael Nadal with his fury, faith and wounded endurance; Novak Djokovic, the last great disruptor, who has also now reached the stage where each tournament is shadowed by the thought of how many more are left.

In cricket, Virat Kohli has moved from prodigy to elder statesman, playing just one format. And now football's old gods, too, are being claimed by time.

Their ageing has a way of confronting us with our own. You notice the greying beard in the mirror. The stiffness in your back after a long flight. The niggling pain in your knee after the walk to the stadium media centre. You tell

« Every ending reminds us that another piece of our own sporting life is passing into memory »